Insights into the Academic Language Learning of Somali Elementary Students

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Introduction

- There are two languages in the American school system: standard American English and a hidden language: *Academic Language*.
- Standard English is the vocabulary of conversation (Tier 1 words from Common Core standards).
- Academic language is used in higher learning and may not be directly taught in the classroom. Emergent Bilingual (EB) students suffer the most from this normative practice.
- This research focuses on how Somali EB students:
  - become bilingual students
  - acquire academic language

Literature Review

- For EB students to be successful in school and in higher education, they need to have a large vocabulary that includes academic vocabulary (Cummins, 2003; Snow, Lawrence, & White, 2009).
- There is limited research on reading proficiency within the Somali community in the US.
- Most research on Somali students comes from Canada and Europe and is outdated.
- Somali language is among the Top 5 languages spoken by EB/ELL students in 12 states, including MN (Fig.1).

Top 5 Languages Spoken By MN EB/ELL Students

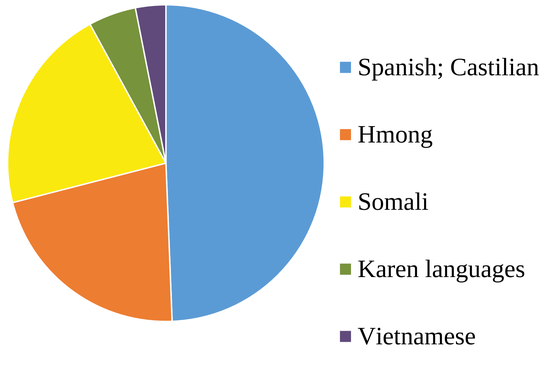


Figure 1

Selected Academic Vocabulary



Tier 2 Academic Vocabulary

Methods

- The data were derived from a 7 year long longitudinal study with students who spoke Somali, Spanish, and Hmong at home.
- The research design is mixed methods. Extant data from researchers who had observed the students 9 times a year and collected information by giving assessments such as the LAS-O which is used to track progress in English fluency. They also collected writing samples and transcribed students' oral language.
- The extant data was reviewed of students' oral and written vocabulary and then compared their language to the First 4,000 words list and its zones (Graves, 2009).

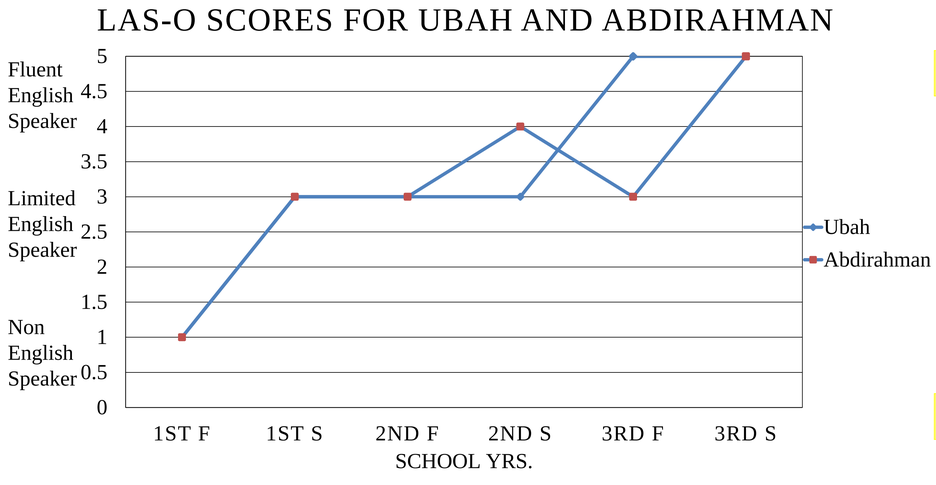


Figure 2: Somali Students

Preliminary Results

- Majority of both students' vocabulary comes from Zone 1 from the First 4,000 Words.
- An initial review of the data shows that both students are using grade level appropriate vocabulary, and some academic vocabulary.
- The results show that neither student came to school with extensive academic vocabulary.
- By grade 5, both students showed broader use of academic vocabulary.

Discussion

- An understanding of vocabulary words is necessary for reading comprehension.
- Academic language is important for students to learn, but there's not enough time in the day to teach separately. Academic vocabulary must be consciously integrated into lesson plans (Helman, 2012).
- Further investigation on the positive acquisition of the students' academic vocabulary is needed.
- Somali language is missing from major lists that count the primary languages EB students speak.
- More research is needed on understanding Somali language and Somali students second language acquisition.

References

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